No More Monsters Here

By Marcus Gardley

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: Actor: Doc, Greatest Grand, Employer and Ookie
Actress: Rebecca and Raheem

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *On February 26, 2012, Trayvon Martin, an unarmed African American teen dressed in a hooded sweatshirt, was walking home from a convenience store in Sanford, Florida.*
ACTOR: *He was fatally shot by George Zimmerman, a neighborhood watch volunteer.*
ACTRESS: *Zimmerman claimed self-defense under the auspices of the "Stand Your Ground" law.*
ACTOR: *He was charged with second-degree murder.*
ACTRESS: *He was acquitted.*
ACTOR: *Follow closely the most recent high-profile shootings of black men.*
ACTRESS: *Say their names:*
ACTOR: *Michael Brown,* ***ACTRESS:*** *in Ferguson, MO;*
ACTOR: *George Floyd* ***ACTRESS:*** *in Minneapolis, MN and*
ACTOR: *Ahmaud Arbery* ***ACTRESS:*** *in Brunswick, GA (to name just a few)*
ACTOR: *You'll notice a pattern.*
ACTRESS: *Only the slightest level of alleged misconduct or "suspicious" behavior is used to justify the fear that led to their deaths.*
ACTOR: *Fear – reasonable or unreasonable?*
ACTRESS: *No More Monsters Here by Marcus Gardley explores the question:*
ACTOR: *Can you truly understand someone until you've walked a mile in their shoes?*

(A black psychiatrist looks over a patient's file. The patient is a white woman.)

REBECCA: **(Pg 79-93)** What's up, Doc? You look worried. What's the diagnosis? Am I insane? I'm insane, aren't I?

DOC: Insane is such a strong word, Rebecca.

REBECCA: Oh God, I knew it! I'm my mother.

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DOC: No, no, no. Calm down. Take a deep breath. What you have is totally normal… unfortunately. Plus there is a cure. You have negroidphobia.

REBECCA: Hold the phone. I got negro what?

DOC: Negroidphobia. It's a fear of people of African descent -- primarily black men. Just as arachnophobia is a fear of spiders and alektorophobia is a fear of chickens, you have Negroidphobia which is a fear of nig-

REBECCA: -- Shut the gate, are you saying I hate black people! That's a lie! One of my neighbors is African American. I've had her over the house for quiche. Plus, I know the theme song to the Fresh Prince of Bell Air. How can I be racist?

DOC: Nobody's saying you're a racist, Becky. I mean, you are but nobody's sayin it. Racism implies that you see a culture as inferior or superior to another. It is a bi-product of privilege. No one can cure that but Jesus. What you have is more specific.

REBECCA: I'm offended.

DOC: Wow. You fear black men because you have bought into the myth that they are violent and you're the one that is offended. Classic projection. *(He writes on his pad)*

REBECCA: This is going to sound racist, cliché and ignorant but honestly one of my best friends is a black. Shoronda. We got a secret handshake, she taught me how to twerk, I ate chicken at her church one Easter, plus she lets me touch her hair.

DOC: I guess Doctor King's Dream has been fully realized then, hunh? WAKE UP! Nobody is saying that you hate blacks, Beckka. I'm saying you ***fear*** blacks. You failed our fear of a black planet test. When a black man walks pass your car, you admit to locking the doors and turning on your car alarm.

REBECCA: Yeah but I wasn't locking it because he was black. I was locking it because he looked scary.

DOC: Exactly!

REBECCA: *(beat)* Oh god. I . . . I really do fear black men. Sweet Jesus, I've become my father. *(She cries)*

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DOC: There, there, there, Beckett. It's okay. The first step to recovery is admitting [it]. You came to me because you've been having nightmares about Favor Flav [(1)] hiding in your closet. This fear you have is real. But a lot of Caucazoids have it. And that's why I invented a cure. It's in its experimental stages but so far it has helped a significant number of whites who have undergone treatment. The process only takes a few days.

REBECCA: What do I have to do?

DOC: It's simple. You just have to put on this hoodie and live in the hood for three days as a black man. *(Doc hands her a black hoodie)* It looks like any old black hoodie but it's actually a state-of-the-art transformational mask. Using holographic imaging, it forms a unique black face to cover your own. If you wear it, it will make you look like a black man. No one will assume that you are a white woman behind the mask. You will be black and literally walk in another man's shoes for three days. This will no doubt cure you of your negroidphobia. Trust me, it's surefire. Go ahead put it on. We can begin our treatment immediately.

REBECCA: Oh, I don't know. Shouldn't I have time to think about this first? What if something happens to me in the hood?

DOC: Be brave, Rebbie. Don't you want to be a fully evolved, open-minded human being for your race? *(Rebecca nods tentatively and quickly puts on the hoodie)* You'll also need to sag your jeans. *(Rebecca tugs her jeans down around her hips)* A cultural ambassador will help you change your walk and voice and attempt to teach you how to do the Harlem Shake[(2)] In time, no one will notice old Rebecca from the new Raheem. *(They shake. Then he Harlem shakes as he exits. She gets dressed and practices her walk. It is ridiculous.)*

********** 24 virtual hours later *************

Greatest Grand enters. She is 162, hunched over to her toes. She wakes Rebecca who has become Raheem.)

GREATEST GRAND: Rise and shine, Raheem. Breakfast is the most imported meal of the day. Gots to eat. Gots to eat black food if you wants to uplift the race.

RAHEEM: Uh . . . I ain't hungry, granny. I'll get something later.

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GREATEST GRAND: Ain't hungry!? Why? Have you gotten too good for soul food? I send you to that good school to gets an edumacation and you got too good for chitlins. You must not be feeling well. Steel grievin' over Ray Ray's death? Shugar, don't you know you live in the hood? You might as well fact the fact that a lot of your homies are gonna get got at a young age. Hell, you 18. You lucky you still livin' your damn self. The black man is an endangered species, baby and you is in danger.

RAHEEM: That's a bit of an exaggeration isn't it? I mean, I see a lot of brothers hanging on the street corner. On the basketball court, at the club. They chillin in the cut on the regular.

GREATEST GRAND: No, they're getting cut down on the regular. Many bodies get laid to rest on the daily because the black male body is the great American sacrifice. History has had it hanging from trees, chained to gangs, burnt to bones and the future's got it slavin behind bars. It must be put out of sight. Cause you're public enemy number one. You still put the fear of God into even the good, hippy, free love, liberal minded folk. The media, the TV, the movies, hell even hip hop makes you out to be a bad ass. But it ain't real. It's just story. Stereotypes hyped up into stereo. But you can take your life and rewrite it, Raheem. Create a future for yourself that is bigger – better than this story you were told to buy into. Ergo baby, you need to get a job. *(She throws a dress coat over him and hands him a tie. He puts it on)* I spent the last of my social security to get you this suit. Don't disappoint me now.

********* **Wal-Mart** **********

EMPLOYER: According to your resume, you have no marketable skills. You've never even held a job before.

RAHEEM: I know but I can't hold down a job if someone doesn't hand one to me.

EMPLOYER: Well, my hands are tied. I can't afford to take a chance on anybody right now.

RAHEEM: - Who says I'm a chance? I could be the best employee you ever had.

EMPLOYER: Fat chance: your resume has misspellings, you arrived thirty-three minutes late to your interview and you have no references.

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RAHEEM: Yeah but this is Walmart. You got old people greeting folks at the door. You sell low quality products made by children in third world countries for poor people in the US many of whom are on welfare. I just want a job, man. I'm trying to bag groceries. Let's keep it real. I can say paper or plastic with a smile. Check this: *(He smiles)* Paper? Plastic?

EMPLOYER: Yeah see, this is not going to work. I don't think you possess the Walmart spirit.

RAHEEM: Look, my grandmother spent the last of her social security check to get me this suit.

EMPLOYER: That's precious. We'll call you if something becomes available. In the meantime, I suggest you find a career more suitable to your work experience.

******* On the streets ********

OOKIE (a street thug): Yo, son I heard you lookin for work. Pray tell, what's your five-year plan, homie?

RAHEEM: Five-year plan? I'm just trin to make it to tomorrow. Trying to pay my Granny back for a suit she bought me.

OOKIE: That's touching but you need a five-year plan, dawg.

RAHEEM: Wait, you sell drugs!

OOKIE: Pharmaceuticals. Drugs got a negative connotation. I sell pharmaceuticals. I feel like you judging me holla hard right now.

RAHEEM: Well, I was thinking of going to college.

OOKIE: College!? You stupid! Corn Nut's brother got a degree from CUNY and right now he workin at the Starbucks on 125th. I make ten times what he make and I don't pay Uncle Sam a penny. Open your eyes cuz, colleges have become corporations. You want to make real money, you got to have an entrepreneurial spirit. You got to focus on product. You got to sell. *(OOKIE hands him several very large sandwich bags stuffed with marijuana)*

RAHEEM: Oh, I don't know. I hear the NYPD is giving brothers ten years just for dime bags. Plus, I don't think I could handle prison, I'm too pretty. *(RAHEEM shows her profile)*

OOKIE: You'll make over 500 dollars a day.

RAHEEM: OMG! Count me in. When can I start?

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OOKIE: Today. I'm giving you some merchandise cause your story touched me and I know you just trying to hep your granny out so . . . do me a favor and don't get caught. Try not to be so . . . how do I put this . . . black.

RAHEEM: Right. I'll see what I can do.

(Raheem walks the street. Tries to remember how he walked when eh was Rebecca, but he can't. He walks. He is being followed by someone. He walks faster – the figure follows him. Eventually, he stops. The figure stops)

RAHEEM: Who's following me? Stop being an asshole and show yourself. I ain't no punk. . Show yourself, I said! *(Silence)* I should known better than makin a drop off in the suburbs. Playa hatin! Aight Raheem, relax. Play it cool, homes. Be Rebecca. Try not to stand out. This is your last day in this hoodie. Last day wearin this mask. Just try to get through the night.

(Again he walks. He tries to walk white. He can't do it. The figure follows again. Raheem runs, falls and the figure falls on top of him. They fight. The figure breaks free and pulls a gun from his pants and points it at RAHEEM. REBECCA screams.)

RAHEEM: Wait! Hold on! I'm not Raheem, I'm not black. I'm Rebecca. I'm white. *(She tries to take the hoodie off but cannot.* I'm Rebecca Smith. This is just an experiment, a cure. Please! Please sir don't . . . don't shoot. Things are not as they seem. I'm not as I . . . I'm a . . . *(The figure cocks his gun. Rebecca screams. He shoots. Rebecca grabs her heart, she wails.) (BEAT- The figure takes his mask off. It is Doc.)*

DOC: It's okay. It's okay Rebecca Smith. It was just a simulation. You are not shot. You are not bleeding. It was not real. You are well now. You are healed.

REBECCA: *(Screams in anger and frustration)*

DOC: You're welcome?

REBECCA: That was not fair! That was not okay! I felt it. I felt the bullet go through me, okay. I felt ***them***. *(She cries)*

DOC: Them?

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REBECCA: Those men. Why'd you do that? Why you make me feel them; their pain. I saw their faces: Medgar Evers, Emmit Till, ***Oscar Grant, Sean Bell, Amidou Diallo***[3] and lynched black men. It was inhumane. It was *wrong*. . . So *WRONG*!!!!

DOC: I have no idea what you're talking about. There ware no men, Rebeck –

REBECCA: DON'T LIE TO ME! You used me! Got into my head. They're in my head, still. Whispering. They're mad! I'M SO MAD!

DOC: It's just a side-effect, Mrs. Smith. Trust me, you are healed. You are better.

REBECCA: I don't want to be better. I want them out of my head.

DOC: Look, please calm down. I sill want to run a few tests.

REBECCA: NO! Hell no! I will no longer be your test rat. This treatment should be banned. You should have your license revoked. This is racist! *(She grabs her coat and purse)*

DOC: Wow. Okay. So I guess you won't be recommending me to your friends. *(Rebecca screams in frustration and exits, slamming the door.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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1. *William Jonathan Drayton Jr., widely known by his stage name Flavor Flav, is an American rapper, rap "hype man", and television personality. He had co-founded the rap group Public Enemy in 1985 with Chuck D, where he was known especially for his yells of "Yeah, boyeeeeee!" – Consider replacing this name with the name of a current rap icon*

2. ***THE HARLEM SHAKE – VIDEO:*** *https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Mdeu5aGwwWI*
   Originally, Harlem shake referred to a dance that began in Harlem, New York back in 1981. It has its roots in an Ethiopian dance, "Eskista."

3. ***Medgar Evers*** *– Black Civil rights activist who served as the first state field secretary of the NAACP in Mississippi until his assassination in 1963.*
   Emmit Till *-- a 14-year-old African American who was lynched in Mississippi in 1955, after being accused of offending a white woman in her family's grocery store.*
   Oscar Grant *- Oscar Grant was a 22-year-old African-American man who was killed in the early morning hours of New Year's Day 2009 by a Police Officer in Oakland, California*
   Sean Bell *-- Sean Bell was shot in New York City, in the borough of Queens on November 25, 2006. Three men were shot when a total of 50 rounds were fired by New York City police in both plainclothes and undercover.*
   Amidou Diallo - *a 23-year-old Guinean immigrant named Amadou Diallo was fatally shot by four New York City Police Department plainclothes officers*

   NOTE: Consider replacing the last 3 names with cases of black men who have been killed in cases of police brutality. (Perhaps those used in the introduction)

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